A Description of the Āsanas in Chapter XXXI of the Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā

Author: Alexander Vijaya (t.me/alexvijaya)

Preface

This article presents a translation and word-by-word analysis of the eleven principal āsanas listed in chapter XXXI of the *Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā*, a work of the Pāñcarātra tradition. It was prepared from the supplied file *Ahirbudhnya_samhita.txt* and checked against the printed text on pp. 293–296 of volume II of the 1916 edition.

Editorial policy: Readings clearly transmitted in the edition are translated without adding details from modern descriptions of poses with the same names. Unclear passages are not silently emended: they are marked with a question mark, square brackets, or an explanation. Where the transcription file contains an evident OCR error, the reading has been checked against the printed page; for example, the Kūrmāsana verse prints निपीड्य (*nipīḍya*), not the erroneous OCR reading निपीय.

The translation distinguishes three levels: the Sanskrit reading, a literal translation, and a cautious literary translation. Where the Sanskrit does not permit the body's position to be reconstructed unambiguously, this is stated explicitly. Claims about the benefits of poses are presented as statements made by the text, not as verified medical information.

The Edition

Principal printed edition:

M. D. Rāmānujācārya (ed.), under the supervision of F. Otto Schrader, ***Ahirbudhnya-Saṃhitā of the Pāñcarātrāgama****, 2 vols., Adyar Library Series 4. Adyar, Madras, 1916.* Digital copies of both volumes are available via Internet Archive 2; the first edition is also catalogued by HathiTrust 7.

The present transcription corresponds to the section on pp. 293–296 of the printed second volume. A second edition, revised by V. Krishnamacharya (Adyar Library and Research Centre, 1966), appeared later; it should not be confused with the first-edition text on which this work is based. The bibliographical details of the second edition are confirmed by the catalogue 4.

The 1916 edition provides manuscript variants alongside the text. The main printed reading is therefore retained below, with variants relevant to this passage noted separately.

Dating and Probable Place of Composition

The date of the *Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā* is disputed; the dates of the manuscripts used for the printed edition do not in themselves establish the date of composition.

In the section “Provenience and Age” of his introduction, F. Otto Schrader associated the text with Kashmir. Among the arguments he adduces are the mention of yantra diagrams on birch bark in chapters 26 and 45; the image in chapter 39 of the sun emerging from an obstacle of snow; and the account of Muktāpīḍa in chapter 48. Schrader stressed that little can be said with certainty about the text’s age: he placed it in a group of Saṃhitās for which he proposed the eighth century CE as an upper limit. As a possible lower limit, he considered the text’s presentation of Buddhism as divided into three major schools; in Schrader’s view, this implies a date after the establishment of Mahāyāna, approximately after 300 CE. These are Schrader’s dating arguments, not an established date for the text. See the sections of his introduction on the manuscripts, provenance, and age, pp. 94–99 6.

In a 2017 article, D. Wujastyk proposes a date after 1000 CE, and possibly South India, for the *Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā* 5. Marion Rastelli’s 2018 article abstract likewise associates the text’s composition with South India, narrowing the hypothesis to the twelfth–thirteenth centuries 3. These later proposals differ substantially from Schrader’s earlier dating framework; without additional evidence, they cannot be collapsed into one precise date or presented as an agreed consensus. Accordingly, this article does not assign a date to the āsana section itself.

The Manuscripts Used by the Editor

According to Schrader’s introduction, over the three years spent preparing the edition, he was able to obtain “six (nine)” manuscripts. The editor noted that all descend from a single already-corrupt archetype, although he considered the text of the Saṃhitā generally well preserved. The introduction does not assign the manuscripts one absolute date; Schrader speaks primarily of their relative age and quality.

Of the two witnesses he identifies as oldest and best, **E** is a Grantha-script manuscript from Kalale in Mysore; **D** is a Malayalam-script manuscript belonging to the Mahārāja of Travancore. Schrader judges E to be more accurate than D. Several manuscripts from Melkote, descendants of E and almost identical to one another, were grouped by the editor under the common siglum **F**. Among the other witnesses he describes are a palm-leaf Grantha manuscript at the Adyar Library (**A**), a paper Grantha manuscript from the same library with large omissions (**C**), and a Telugu-script manuscript belonging to the Government of Mysore (**B**). He did not include a severely damaged manuscript from Tanjore.

Thus, this passage is not based on a single manuscript: the printed apparatus cites sigla for several witnesses. At the same time, according to Schrader, these witnesses are not fully independent, since they descend from a common corrupt source. Manuscript details are from Schrader’s introduction, pp. 94–95 6.

The Chapter and Its Numbering

Chapter XXXI is entitled in the colophon योगाङ्गयमनियमासननिरूपणम् — “Exposition of the limbs of yoga, yama, niyama, and āsana.” The supplied excerpt does not begin at the chapter’s opening: it continues a discussion of yama and niyama, then describes the āsanas and moves on to the purification of nāḍīs (bodily channels) before prāṇāyāma. In Schrader’s synopsis, from 31.14 to the end of chapter XXXII the text presents the eight limbs of yoga: ten yamas, ten niyamas, eleven principal āsanas, prāṇāyāma with an introduction to the nāḍīs and the ten bodily vāyus, and a three-month purification of the nāḍī system; the remaining limbs follow. This is provided here only as context: the adjacent sections are not translated in full 6. The appendix includes the concluding lines on the nāḍīs and the colophon.

The text lists **eleven principal āsanas**: Cakra, Padma, Kūrma, Mayūra, Kukkuṭa, Vīra, Svastika, Bhadra, Siṃha, Mukta, and Gomukha. This is the list given by the Saṃhitā; it does not mean that the work claims there are only eleven poses.

Printed verse numbers have been retained wherever legible. Some numbers are not recognized in the supplied transcription. In particular, the Mayūrāsana passage is treated as verses 36–37; the Kukkuṭāsana passage falls between 37 and 39; and the Muktāsana description continues to half of verse 45. D. Wujastyk marks Muktāsana as 44–45ab and Gomukhāsana as 45cd–46; that division is followed here. Thus, in the printed layout, the heading for Gomukhāsana falls in the middle of verse 45; the text is not rearranged editorially to remove this feature 5.

Sources

- Primary text: the supplied file *Ahirbudhnya_samhita.txt*; printed original: *Ahirbudhnya-Saṃhitā of the Pāñcarātrāgama*, vol. II, pp. 293–296, 1916 edition 2.
- F. Otto Schrader, *Introduction to the Pañcarātra and the Ahirbudhnya Saṃhitā*. Adyar Library, 1916, especially pp. 94–99 and 123–125 6.
- Dominik Wujastyk, “The Yoga Texts Attributed to Yājñavalkya and their Remarks on Posture,” *Asian Literature and Translation* 4, no. 1 (2017): 159–186. Used for comparison and for interpretations of unclear passages that are explicitly identified as such 5.
- Marion Rastelli, “Considerations About Traditions Influential in the Ahirbudhnyasaṃhitā,” *Asiatische Studien* 72, no. 2 (2018): 421–443 3.
- Second edition: M. D. Rāmānujācārya, F. O. Schrader, V. Krishnamacharya, *Ahirbudhnya-Saṃhitā of the Pāñcarātrāgama*, 2nd ed., Adyar Library and Research Centre, 1966 4.

The Principal Āsanas of Chapter XXXI: Sanskrit Text and Translation

Opening and List of Āsanas

The rubric preceding the list reads अथासनानां स्वास्थ्यहेतुत्वम् — “Now, on āsanas as a cause of health / well-being.”

Devanāgarī

> आसनानि प्रवक्ष्यामि मुख्यानि विविधानि च ।
> आस्थायैषामन्यतमं योगिनो यान्ति निर्वृतिम् ॥

IAST

> āsanāni pravakṣyāmi mukhyāni vividhāni ca ।
> āsthāyaiṣām anyatamaṃ yogino yānti nirvṛtim ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> āсанāни правакшйāми мукхйāни вивидхāни ча ।
> āстхāйаишāм анйатамаṁ йогино йāнти нирвр̣тим ॥

Word-by-word analysis

āsanāni — āsanas; pravakṣyāmi — I shall explain; mukhyāni — principal; vividhāni — diverse; ca — and; āsthāya — having assumed; eṣām — of these; anyatamam — one; yoginaḥ — yogins; yānti — attain, go to; nirvṛtim — repose, tranquillity.

Literal translation

I shall explain the principal and diverse āsanas; having assumed one of them, yogins attain repose.

Literary translation

“I shall explain the principal poses. By assuming one of them, the yogin attains repose.”

List, verses 31–32

Devanāgarī

> चक्रं पद्मासनं कूर्म मायूरं कौक्कुटं तथा ॥३१॥
> वीरासनं स्वस्तिकं च भद्रं सिंहासनं तथा ।
> मुक्तासनं गोमुखं च मुख्यान्येतानि नारद ॥३२॥

IAST

> cakraṃ padmāsanaṃ kūrma māyūraṃ kaukkuṭaṃ tathā ॥31॥
> vīrāsanaṃ svastikaṃ ca bhadraṃ siṃhāsanaṃ tathā ।
> muktāsanaṃ gomukhaṃ ca mukhyāny etāni nārada ॥32॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> чакраṁ падмāсанаṁ кӯрма мāйӯраṁ кауккуṭаṁ татхā ॥31॥
> вӣрāсанаṁ свастикаṁ ча бхадраṁ симхāсанаṁ татхā ।
> муктāсанаṁ гомукхаṁ ча мукхйāнӣ етāни нāрада ॥32॥

Word-by-word analysis

cakram — Cakra; padmāsanam — Padmāsana; kūrma — Kūrma; māyūram — Mayūra; kaukkuṭam — Kukkuṭa; tathā — likewise; vīrāsanam — Vīrāsana; svastikam — Svastika; ca — and; bhadram — Bhadra; siṃhāsanam — Siṃhāsana; muktāsanam — Muktāsana; gomukham — Gomukha; mukhyāni — principal; etāni — these; nārada — O Nārada.

Translation

Cakra, Padma, Kūrma, Mayūra, and Kukkuṭa; likewise Vīrāsana, Svastika, Bhadra, and Siṃhāsana; Muktāsana and Gomukha—these are the principal [āsanas], O Nārada.

1. Cakrāsana (“Wheel Pose”) — verse 33

Devanāgarī

> सव्योरुं दक्षिणे गुल्फे दक्षिणं दक्षिणेतरे ।
> निदध्यादृजुकायस्तु चक्रासनमिदं परम् ॥३३॥

IAST

> savyoruṃ dakṣiṇe gulphe dakṣiṇaṃ dakṣiṇetare ।
> nidadhyād ṛjukāyas tu cakrāsanam idaṃ param ॥33॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> савйоруṁ дакшиṇе гулпхе дакшиṇаṁ дакшиṇетаре ।
> нидадхйāд ṛджукāйас ту чакрāсанам идаṁ парам ॥33॥

Word-by-word analysis

savya-ūruṃ — the left thigh; dakṣiṇe gulphe — on the right ankle; dakṣiṇaṃ — the right [thigh; the noun is implied]; dakṣiṇa-itare — on the other, i.e. non-right, side [the noun modified is not repeated]; nidadhyāt — let him place; ṛju-kāyaḥ — with the body erect; tu — indeed; cakrāsanam idam param — this supreme Cakrāsana.

Literal translation

Let him place the left thigh on the right ankle, and the right [thigh] on the other [ankle / side]; [he should remain] with the body erect. This is the supreme Cakrāsana.

Literary translation

Cakrāsana — “Wheel Pose.” The text describes placing the left thigh by the right ankle and the right thigh on the opposite side, with the body held straight. The second half of the description is grammatically compressed: the word “ankle” is not repeated after “right,” so the exact configuration cannot be established without conjecture.

2. Padmāsana (“Lotus Pose”) — verse 34

Devanāgarī

> ऊर्वोरुपरि संस्थाप्य उभे पादतले सुखम् ।
> पद्मासनमिदं प्रोक्तं सर्वकिल्बिषनाशनम् ॥३४॥

IAST

> ūrvor upari saṃsthāpya ubhe pādatale sukham ।
> padmāsanam idaṃ proktaṃ sarvakilbiṣanāśanam ॥34॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> ӯрвор упари саṁстхāпйа убхе пāдатале сукхам ।
> падмāсанам идаṁ проктаṁ сарвакилбишанāш́анам ॥34॥

Word-by-word analysis

ūrvoḥ upari — above the thighs; saṃsthāpya — having placed; ubhe — both; pādatale — the soles of the feet; sukham — comfortably; padmāsanam — Padmāsana; idam — this; proktam — is called; sarva-kilbiṣa-nāśanam — destroying all sins.

Literal translation

Having comfortably placed both soles above the thighs, [the yogin assumes] this Padmāsana, said to destroy all sins.

Literary translation

Padmāsana — “Lotus Pose”: both soles are placed comfortably above the thighs. The verse calls this pose a destroyer of all sins; it does not specify which foot goes on which side.

3. Kūrmāsana (“Tortoise Pose”) — verse 35

Devanāgarī

> गुदं निपीड्य गुल्फाभ्यां व्युत्क्रमेण समाहितः ।
> एतत्कूर्मासनं प्रोक्तं योगसिद्धिकरं परम् ॥३५॥

IAST

> gudaṃ nipīḍya gulphābhyāṃ vyutkrameṇa samāhitaḥ ।
> etat kūrmāsanaṃ proktaṃ yogasiddhikaraṃ param ॥35॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> гудаṁ нипӣдйа гулпхāбхйāṁ вйуткрамеṇа самāхитаḥ ।
> етат кӯрмāсанаṁ проктаṁ йогасиддхикараṁ парам ॥35॥

Word-by-word analysis

gudam — the anus; nipīḍya — having pressed, compressed; gulphābhyām — with both ankles / by means of both ankles; vyutkrameṇa — in reverse order; samāhitaḥ — composed, concentrated; etat — this; kūrmāsanam — Kūrmāsana; proktam — is said to be; yoga-siddhi-karam — bringing success in yoga; param — supreme.

Literal translation

Having pressed the anus and [placed the legs] with the ankles in reverse order, [the yogin] is composed. This Kūrmāsana is said to be supreme and to bring success in yoga.

Literary translation

Kūrmāsana — "Tortoise Pose." The verse mentions pressing the anus and arranging the ankles in reverse order, but does not describe the precise placement of the legs. The pose is called supreme and conducive to success in yoga.

Note: In the supplied transcription, the first verb is read as "निपीय". The printed page reads "निपीड्य" (nipīḍya); the translation follows the printed reading.

4. Mayūrāsana ("Peacock Pose") — verses 36–37

Devanāgarī

> निवेश्य कूर्परौ सम्यङ्नाभिमण्डलपार्श्वयोः ।
> अवष्टभ्य भुवं पाणितलाभ्यां व्योम्नि दण्डवत् ॥
> समोन्नतशिरः पादो मायूरासनमिष्यते ।
> एतत्सर्वविषघ्नं च सर्वव्याधिनिवारणम् ॥३७॥

IAST

> niveśya kūrparau samyaṅ nābhimaṇḍalapārśvayoḥ ।
> avaṣṭabhya bhuvaṃ pāṇitalābhyāṃ vyomni daṇḍavat ॥
> samonnataśiraḥ pādo māyūrāsanam iṣyate ।
> etat sarvaviṣaghnaṃ ca sarvavyādhinivāraṇam ॥37॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> нивеш́йа кӯрпарау самйаṅ нābхимаṇḍалапāрш́вайоḥ ।
> авашṭабхйа бхуваṁ пāниталābхйāṁ вйомни даṇḍават ॥
> самонната-ш́ираḥ пāдо мāйӯрāсанам ишйате ।
> етат сарвавишагхнаṁ ча сарвавйāдхинивāраṇам ॥37॥

Word-by-word analysis

niveśya — having placed; kūrparau — both elbows; samyak / samyaṅ — properly; nābhi-maṇḍala-pārśvayoḥ — on either side of the navel region; avaṣṭabhya — leaning on, bracing against; bhuvam — the ground; pāṇi-talābhyām — with both palms; vyomni — in the air; daṇḍa-vat — like a rod or staff. Sam-unnata-śiraḥ-pādaḥ — [one whose] head and feet are raised to the same level; māyūrāsanam — Mayūrāsana; iṣyate — is considered, is

called; etat — this; sarva-viṣa-ghnam — destroying / neutralizing all poisons; ca — and; sarva-vyādhi-nivāraṇam — removing all diseases.

Literal translation

Having properly placed both elbows at the sides of the navel region and braced against the ground with both palms, [the yogin holds the body] in the air like a staff. When the head and feet are raised to the same level, this is considered Mayūrāsana. It destroys all poisons and removes all diseases.

Literary translation

Mayūrāsana — “Peacock Pose.” The elbows are placed on either side of the navel region, with the body supported by both palms. The body is compared to a staff held in the air; the head and feet are raised to the same level. The text attributes to the pose the removal of poisons and diseases.

Note on the edition’s variants: the apparatus gives निरुध्य in D instead of अवष्टभ्य in the first half; E has an alternative reading for the words describing the sides of the navel region. In verse 37, manuscripts E/F read मुच्यते instead of इष्यते, while B/C read निबर्हणम् instead of निवारणम्. The main printed reading is retained; the variants are not adopted as established emendations.

5. Kukkuṭāsana (“Rooster Pose”) — the verse following 37

Devanāgarī

> पद्मासनमधिष्ठाय जान्वन्तरविनिःसृतौ ।
> करौ भूमौ निवेश्यैतद्व्योमस्थं कुक्कुटासनम् ॥

IAST

> padmāsanam adhiṣṭhāya jānvantaraviniḥsṛtau ।
> karau bhūmau niveśyaitad vyomasthaṃ kukkuṭāsanam ॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> падмāсанам адхишт̣хāйа джāнвантаравиниḥср̣тау ।
> карау бхӯмау нивеш́йаитад вйомастхам̇ куккут̣āсанам ॥

Word-by-word analysis

padmāsanam adhiṣṭhāya — having assumed Padmāsana; jānu-antara — between the knees; viniḥsṛtau — projecting outward, extended out; karau — both hands; bhūmau — on the ground; niveśya — having placed; etat — this; vyoma-stham — suspended in the air; kukkuṭāsanam — Kukkuṭāsana.

Literal translation

Having assumed Padmāsana, [the yogin] brings both hands out between the knees and places them on the ground; this is Kukkuṭāsana, suspended in the air.

Literary translation

Kukkuṭāsana — “Rooster Pose.” From Padmāsana, the hands are brought out between the knees and placed on the ground; the pose is described as being suspended in the air.

Note: The verse number is not visible in the supplied transcription. By its position between verses 37 and 39, it corresponds to verse 38; the heading therefore does not present the number as directly legible in the file.

6. Vīrāsana (“Hero Pose”) — verse 39

Devanāgarī

> एकत्रोरुणि संस्थाप्य पादमेकमैथेतरम् ।
> ऊरुं पादे निवेश्यैतद्वीरासनमुदाहृतम् ॥३९॥

IAST

> ekatro ruṇi saṃsthāpya pādam ekam [reading unclear] ।
> ūruṃ pāde niveśyaitad vīrāsanam udāhṛtam ॥39॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> екатро руṇи саṁстхāпйа пāдам екам [unclear reading] ।
> ӯруṁ пāде нивеш́йаитад вӣрāсанам удāхр̣там ॥39॥

Word-by-word analysis

ekatra ūruṇi — at / on one thigh; saṃsthāpya — having placed; pādam ekam — one foot; [after pādam ekam] — reading unclear; ūruṃ — the thigh; pāde — on the foot; niveśya — having placed; etat vīrāsanam — this is Vīrāsana; udāhṛtam — is called.

Literal translation

Having placed [something] by one thigh and one foot … (the reading पादमेकमैथेतरम् is unclear) …, having placed the thigh on the foot, [this] is called Vīrāsana.

Literary translation

Vīrāsana — “Hero Pose.” The line preserved in the edition appears to describe the relative positions of a foot and a thigh, but its first half does not allow the sides or sequence to be established with confidence. The exact configuration is therefore not reconstructed here.

D. Wujastyk likewise describes verse 31.39 as less clear, but probably close in meaning to the description of Vīrāsana in the *Vimānārcanākalpa*: a foot is placed on a thigh, and a thigh on a foot. This is a comparative scholarly interpretation, not a reading that can be derived unambiguously from the unclear line of the *Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā* 5.

7. Svastikāsana (“Swastika Pose / Auspicious Sign”) — verse 40

Devanāgarī

> उभे पादतले कृत्वा जानूर्वोरन्तरे दृढम् ।
> ऋजुकायः समासीत स्वस्तिकं तत्प्रचक्षते ॥४०॥

IAST

> ubhe pādatale kṛtvā jānūrv-or antare dṛḍham ।
> ṛjukāyaḥ samāsīta svastikaṃ tat pracakṣate ॥40॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> убхе пāдатале кр̣твā джāнӯрвор антаре др̣дхам ।
> р̣джукāйах̣ самāсӣта свастикам̇ тат прачакшате ॥40॥

Word-by-word analysis

ubhe — both; pādatale — soles of the feet; kṛtvā — having placed; jānu-ūrvoḥ antare — between the knees and thighs; dṛḍham — firmly; ṛju-kāyaḥ — with the body straight; samāsīta — let him sit; svastikam — Svastika; tat pracakṣate — this is what it is called.

Literal translation

Having firmly placed both soles between the knees and thighs, let him sit with the body straight; this is called Svastikāsana.

Literary translation

In Svastikāsana, both soles are placed firmly between the knees and thighs, and the body is held straight. The verse does not separately state how the legs are crossed.

8. Bhadrāsana (“Auspicious Pose”) — verse 41

Devanāgarī

> सीवन्याः पार्श्वयोर्गुल्फौ निवेश्यापदे दृढम् ।
> बध्वा कराभ्यां तत्प्रोक्तं भद्रासनमघापहम् ॥४१॥

IAST

> sīvanyāḥ pārśvayor gulphau niveśyāpade dṛḍham ।
> badhvā karābhyāṃ tat proktaṃ bhadrāsanam aghāpaham ॥41॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> сӣванйāх̣ пāрш́вайор гулпхау нивеш́йāпаде др̣дхам ।
> бадхвā карāбхйāм̇ тат проктам̇ бхадрāсанам агхāпахам ॥41॥

Word-by-word analysis

sīvanyāḥ — the seam; by context, the perineal seam; pārśvayoḥ — on either side; gulphau — the two ankles; niveśya — having placed; āpade — as printed; the meaning of this reading in the phrase is unclear; dṛḍham — firmly; badhvā — “having bound / secured” (the printed

form is not emended); karābhyām — with both hands; tat proktam — this is said to be; bhadrāsanam — Bhadrāsana; agha-apaham — removing sin / evil.

Literal translation

Having placed both ankles on either side of the perineal seam, … (the reading निवेश्यापदे दृढम् is unclear) …, having firmly bound / secured [the position] with both hands, this is called Bhadrāsana, which removes sin.

Literary translation

Bhadrāsana — "Auspicious Pose." The verse appears to direct that the ankles be placed on either side of the perineal seam and that the position be secured with both hands. The word अपदे in the printed line cannot be translated with confidence here; the missing detail is not conjecturally supplied.

9. Siṃhāsana ("Lion Pose") — verses 42–43

Devanāgarī

> सीवन्याः पार्श्वयोर्गुल्फौ व्युत्क्रमेण निवेश्य च ।
> करौ जान्वोर्निधायोभौ प्रसार्य निखिलाङ्गुलीः ॥
> नासाग्रन्यस्तनयनो व्यात्तवक्त्रो ऋजुः सुधीः ।
> एतत्सिंहासनं प्रोक्तं सर्वदेवाभिपूजितम् ॥४३॥

IAST

> sīvanyāḥ pārśvayor gulphau vyutkrameṇa niveśya ca ।
> karau jānvornidhāyobhau prasārya nikhilāṅgulīḥ ॥
> nāsāgranyastanayano vyāttavaktro ṛjuḥ sudhīḥ ।
> etat siṃhāsanaṃ proktaṃ sarvadevābhipūjitam ॥43॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> сӣванйāх̣ пāрш́вайор гулпхау вйуткрамеṇа нивеш́йа ча ।
> карау джāнворнидхāйобхау прасāрйа никхилāṅгулӣх̣ ॥
> нāсāгранйастанайано вйāттавактро р̣джух̣ судхӣх̣ ।
> етат симха̄санам̇ проктам̇ сарвадевāбхипӯджитам ॥43॥

Word-by-word analysis

sīvanyāḥ pārśvayoḥ — on either side of the perineal seam; gulphau — both ankles; vyutkrameṇa — in reverse order; niveśya — having placed; ca — and; karau — both hands; jānvoḥ — on the knees; nidhāya ubhau — having placed both; prasārya — stretching, extending; nikhila-aṅgulīḥ — all the fingers. Nāsāgra-nyasta-nayanaḥ — [one whose] gaze is fixed on the tip of the nose; vyātta-vaktraḥ — with the mouth wide open; ṛjuḥ — straight; sudhīḥ — wise; etat — this; siṃhāsanam — Siṃhāsana; proktam — is said to be; sarva-deva-abhipūjitam — honoured by all the gods.

Literal translation

Having placed the ankles on either side of the perineal seam in reverse order, and placed both hands on the knees with all the fingers extended, [the yogin], with the gaze fixed on the tip of the nose, mouth wide open, body straight, and discerning mind, is said to be in Siṃhāsana, honoured by all the gods.

Literary translation

Siṃhāsana — “Lion Pose”: the ankles are placed on either side of the perineal seam, both hands rest on the knees, and all the fingers are extended. The gaze is directed to the tip of the nose, the mouth is wide open, and the body is straight. The text says that all the gods honour this pose.

D. Wujastyk translates the description as a position with the ankles crossed at the perineal seam, the hands on the knees, the fingers extended, the gaze at the tip of the nose, and the mouth wide open; he also notes a close verbal parallel in another medieval yogic text 5. In the present translation, “crossed” is not added to the main text: the Sanskrit says व्युत्क्रमेण, “in reverse order.”

10. Muktāsana (“Pose of the Liberated”) — verses 44–45ab

Devanāgarī

> मेढ्रादुपरि विन्यस्य सव्यगुल्फमिहेतरम् ।
> गुल्फं विन्यस्य पाणी चाप्यङ्गमध्ये निवेश्य च ॥
> मुक्तासनमिदं प्रोक्तं स्थिता यत्र मुमुक्षवः ।

IAST

> meḍhrād upari vinyasya savyagulpham ihetaram ।
> gulphaṃ vinyasya pāṇī cāpy aṅgamadhye niveśya ca ॥
> muktāsanam idaṃ proktaṃ sthitā yatra mumukṣavaḥ ।

Cyrillic transliteration

> медхрāд упари винйасйа савйагулпхам ихетарам ।
> гулпхаṁ винйасйа пāṇī чāпй аṅгамадхйе нивеш́йа ча ॥
> муктāсанам идаṁ проктаṁ стхитā йатра мумукш̣аваḥ ।

Word-by-word analysis

meḍhrāt upari — above the genital organ; vinyasya — having placed; savya-gulpham — the left ankle; iha itaram — here, the other [ankle]; gulpham vinyasya — having placed the ankle; pāṇī — both hands; ca api — also; aṅga-madhye — in the middle of the body; niveśya — having placed; muktāsanam idam — this Muktāsana; proktam — is called; sthitā yatra — where they abide; mumukṣavaḥ — those seeking liberation.

Literal translation

Having placed the left ankle above the genital organ, and here the other [ankle], then placing the ankle and both hands in the middle of the body, this is called Muktāsana, where those seeking liberation abide.

Literary translation

Muktāsana — “Pose of the Liberated.” The left ankle is placed above the genital organ, with the other beside it; then the ankle and hands are positioned in the middle of the body. According to the text, this is the pose in which those seeking liberation abide.

D. Wujastyk translates this passage similarly: the left ankle is placed above the genital organ, the other beside it, and the hands are placed in the middle of the body; he assigns the lines to verses 44–45ab 5.

11. Gomukhāsana (“Cow-Face Pose”) — verses 45cd–46

Devanāgarī

> उभयोर्गुल्फयोः कृत्वा पृष्ठपार्श्वावुभावपि ॥४५॥
> व्युत्क्रमेणाथ पाणिभ्यां विन्यस्ताभ्यां विगृह्य च ।
> पृष्ठगाभ्यां पदाङ्गुष्ठावेतद्गोमुखमुच्यते ॥४६॥

IAST

> ubhayor gulphayoḥ kṛtvā pṛṣṭhapārśvāv ubhāv api ॥45॥
> vyutkrameṇātha pāṇibhyāṃ vinyastābhyāṃ vigṛhya ca ।
> pṛṣṭhagābhyāṃ padāṅguṣṭhāv etad gomukham ucyate ॥46॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> убхайор гулпхайоḥ кр̣твā пр̣шт̣хапāрiшвāв убхāв апи ॥45॥
> вйуткрамеṇāтха пāṇибхйāṁ винйастāбхйāṁ вигр̣хйа ча ।
> пр̣шт̣хагāбхйāṁ падāṅгушт̣хāв етад гомукхам учйате ॥46॥

Word-by-word analysis

ubhayor gulphayoḥ — at / on both ankles (genitive and locative dual); kṛtvā — having placed, arranged; pṛṣṭha-pārśvau — both rear sides / the two sides of the back [the syntactic relation is unclear]; ubhau api — both; vyutkrameṇa — in reverse order; atha — then; pāṇibhyām — with both hands; vinyastābhyām — positioned; vigṛhya — having grasped, held; pṛṣṭha-gābhyām — located behind / extended backward; padāṅguṣṭhau — the great toes; etat — this; gomukham — Gomukha; ucyate — is called.

Literal translation

[Having arranged the ankles and the rear sides of the body in a position that is described but syntactically unclear], then placing both hands in reverse order and grasping the great toes located behind, this is called Gomukha.

Literary translation

Gomukhāsana — “Cow-Face Pose.” The text associates the pose with both ankles, the back of the body, and grasping the great toes with the hands. However, the relation among व्युत्क्रमेण, पृष्ठगाभ्याम्, and पदाङ्गुष्ठौ is not fully clear; the exact position of the legs and arms is not reconstructed beyond what the reading permits.

As a comparative interpretation, D. Wujastyk describes the pose as having the legs crossed and the arms crossed behind the back, with each hand grasping the great toe of the opposite foot. This is a useful scholarly interpretation of a difficult description, but not the only possible literal parsing of every word [5].

Appendix. Transition to Prāṇāyāma and the End of the Chapter

After the āsanas, the text moves directly to the purification of the nāḍīs.

Devanāgarī

> प्राणायामप्रसिद्ध्यर्थं नाडीशुद्धिमनन्तरम् ।
> देहस्थवायुभिः कुर्यात्सानिभिश्च तपोधन ॥४७॥

IAST

> prāṇāyāma-prasiddhyarthaṃ nāḍīśuddhim anantaram ।
> dehasthavāyubhiḥ kuryāt sānibhiś ca tapodhana ॥47॥

Cyrillic transliteration

> прāṇāйāмапрасиддхйартхаṁ нāḍйīшуддхим анантарам ।
> дехастхавāйубхиḥ курйāт сāнибхиīш ча таподхана ॥47॥

Word-by-word analysis

prāṇāyāma-prasiddhi-artham — for the success of prāṇāyāma; nāḍī-śuddhim — purification of the nāḍīs, the bodily channels; anantaram — after this; deha-stha-vāyubhiḥ — by means of the vāyus (“winds”) within the body; kuryāt — let one perform; sānibhiḥ ca — so printed; the reading and meaning are unclear; tapodhana — O ascetic, rich in tapas.

Translation

For success in prāṇāyāma, after purification of the nāḍīs, one should practice by means of the winds residing in the body, … (the reading सानिभिश्च is unclear) … O ascetic.

Colophon

> इति श्रीपाञ्चरात्रे तन्त्ररहस्ये अहिर्बुध्न्यसंहितायां
> योगाङ्गयमनियमासननिरूपणं नामैकत्रिंशोऽध्यायः ।
> ओम् । (आदितः श्लोकाः १८७२)

IAST

> iti śrīpāñcarātre tantrarahasye ahirbudhnyasaṃhitāyāṃ
> yogāṅga-yama-niyama-āsana-nirūpaṇaṃ nāma ekatriṃśo 'dhyāyaḥ ।
> om । (āditaḥ ślokāḥ 1872)

Translation

Thus ends chapter XXXI of the *Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā* in the *Tantrarahasya* of the Pāñcarātra, entitled “Exposition of the limbs of yoga, yama, niyama, and āsana.” Om. The printed colophon states: “from the beginning, 1,872 verses.”

Notes on Readings and Translations

1. **Number of āsanas.** The eleven principal poses are listed in verses 31–32 of the *Ahirbudhnya-saṃhitā* itself. Schrader also notes eleven principal āsanas in his survey of the chapter 6.
2. **Verse numbering.** Some verse numbers are omitted or not recognized by OCR in the supplied transcription. For Mayūrāsana, Wujastyk’s scholarly publication explicitly gives verses 36–37; for Siṃhāsana, 42–43; Muktāsana is divided into 44–45ab, and Gomukhāsana into 45cd–46 5. Thus verse 45 in the printed sequence falls across the boundary between two pose names.
3. **The Kūrmāsana verse.** The OCR of the supplied file incorrectly reads निपीय; the printed original has निपीड्य (*nipīḍya*). This is a reading checked against the scan, not a conjectural emendation.
4. **Mayūrāsana, verses 36–37.** The apparatus gives निरुध्य (D) in the first verse instead of अवष्टभ्य; E offers an alternative reading for the words describing the sides of the navel region. In verse 37, manuscripts E/F read मुच्यते instead of इष्यते, and B/C read निबर्हणम् instead of निवारणम्. The main printed readings are retained in the translation.
5. **Vīrāsana, verse 39.** The line पादमेकमैथेतरम् is left unemended; in the IAST and Cyrillic transliterations its place is marked as unclear. Its literal structure does not reliably establish the precise sequence of sides. Wujastyk’s comparison with the description in the *Vimānārcanākalpa* is cited only as an external scholarly parallel, not as an emendation to the text.
6. **Bhadrāsana, verse 41.** The reading निवेश्यापदे is retained as printed; अपदे cannot be interpreted with confidence here. The object of “having secured / bound with both hands” is also not stated explicitly.
7. **Siṃhāsana, verses 42–43.** Part of the word व्यात्तवक्त्रो is damaged or missing in the supplied transcription; the printed page permits it to be read as “with the mouth wide open.” This is a check against the printed original, not an addition from another text.
8. **Muktāsana and Gomukhāsana, verses 44–46.** The apparatus gives D’s variant च हस्तमध्ये for चाप्यङ्गमध्ये; E has another, not fully clear reading. In the next verse D reads प्रगृह्य for विगृह्य. The main reading is retained unchanged.
9. **Verse 47.** The form सानिभिश्च is unclear in the printed text. Only the grammatically discernible parts are translated; the meaning of the final word is not reconstructed.
10. **Historical meanings of the names.** The translations “lion pose,” “peacock pose,” and “cow-face pose” convey the meanings of the Sanskrit names but do not claim that these old descriptions are identical to modern āsanas bearing the same names. Scholarly literature notes substantial variation in descriptions of poses across texts and periods 5.

This translation and word-by-word analysis are based on the supplied transcription of chapter XXXI, checked against the 1916 printed edition; modern interpretations are referenced only where explicitly noted.